

CBT Session Transcript

Therapist: Good afternoon, Sarah. How have things been since our last session?

Patient: It's been a rough week. I keep thinking I'm failing at work. Every small mistake feels huge.

Therapist: Can you walk me through a recent situation where you felt that way?

Patient: Yesterday my supervisor corrected part of a report I submitted. After that, I couldn't stop thinking, "I'm terrible at my job."

Therapist: When that thought came up — "I'm terrible at my job" — how intense was your anxiety from 0 to 10?

Patient: Probably an 8.

Therapist: And what emotions did you notice besides anxiety?

Patient: Shame. Embarrassment. I also felt hopeless.

Therapist: Let's slow the moment down. Your supervisor corrected part of your report. What evidence did your mind use to conclude that you're terrible at your job?

Patient: Well... the report had errors.

Therapist: Okay. Were there any facts that might not support the conclusion?

Patient: I guess the rest of the report was fine. And my supervisor said the corrections were "minor."

Therapist: That's important. Sometimes our thoughts jump from "I made a mistake" to "I'm incompetent." That's a cognitive distortion called overgeneralization. Does that fit what happened?

Patient: Yeah, definitely. I turned one mistake into proof that I'm a failure.

Therapist: If a coworker made the same mistake, would you think they were terrible at their job?

Patient: No. I'd probably think they were just human.

Therapist: What makes it harder to apply that same standard to yourself?

Patient: I feel like I'm supposed to be perfect all the time.

Therapist: That sounds like a very rigid rule. Where do you think that expectation comes from?

Patient: Growing up, mistakes weren't really tolerated in my house. My parents focused a lot on achievement.

Therapist: That history can shape automatic beliefs. Let's try reframing the original thought. Instead of "I'm terrible at my job," what might be a more balanced statement?

Patient: Maybe... "I made a mistake, but that doesn't mean I'm bad at my job."

Therapist: How believable does that feel right now, from 0 to 100 percent?

Patient: Around 60 percent.

Therapist: That's a good start. What happens to your anxiety level when you say the balanced thought?

Patient: It drops to maybe a 4.

Therapist: Great. That tells us the thought itself is influencing the emotional reaction. For homework this week, I'd like you to keep a thought record. When you notice strong self-criticism, write down:

1. The situation
2. The automatic thought
3. The emotion and intensity
4. Evidence for and against the thought
5. A more balanced replacement thought

Patient: Okay, I can do that.

Therapist: Before we end, what's one thing you're taking away from today's session?

Patient: I think I realized I treat my mistakes as proof that something is wrong with me, instead of seeing them as normal.

Therapist: That's an important insight. We'll continue working on challenging those perfectionistic beliefs next session.

Patient: Thank you. This actually feels helpful.

Therapist: I'm glad to hear that. See you next week.